ZAMORANO

CÉSAR VALLEJO

TWENTY POEMS

chosen and translated by

JOHN KNOEPFLE, JAMES WRIGHT

AND ROBERT BLY

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THOUGHTS ON CÉSAR VALLEJO

WHEN I first translated a poem by César Vallejo, one summer night, I knew that I was in the presence of a personality as appealing as any I had met before. The man is a mystic who is skeptical, a fugitive deeply in love with his home, an isolated man who cannot put aside his painful communion with others. He expresses in masculine tones the massed, present anger of the poor man. And more, there is something very ancient in this Vallejo which gives his voice a force a reader seldom confronts. It is the authority of the oral poets of the Andes, those fashioners of the "harawi," a mystical, inward turning complaint. Its tones can still be heard in lyrics sung in the mountains of Peru and played on records in the homesick barrios of Lima. Born in the Andes of an Indian mother, César Vallejo took this folk form in its essentials, discarding what was superficial and picturesque, and made it the echo chamber for a modern and surrealistic speech.

The art of Vallejo is a way of making disparate things live with each other: a young girl nurses the hour, a man points with a God-murdering finger, a man drowns the length of a throat, a stone walks crouched over in the soul. His ability to astonish with metaphor is matched by a talent for shifting from idiom to idiom. In poems like "Agape," the idiom has a primal simplicity. In, for instance, "The Weary Circles," the poem rises to piercing surrealistic metaphors, and then suddenly drops into the tough, blunt colloquial. Through his work the line springs from or opens into common images of

simple and singular life: bread, the act of eating, of putting on your clothes, the pains in the bones, the weather of the day. His most grave poetry is seeded with the tags and catch-words of common speech, those small phrases which all men use to guard their helplessness before the incomprehensible. Other American poets have his ability to create startling metaphors, but no one that I know of has managed to express with such precision and such range the impossible relationship of a man to his own terrible self and his own terrible times. He whimpers, he denounces, he poses, he sees through himself, he ruminates; he does all the unimaginable things that everyone does. Compared with Vallejo, other poets seem afraid of the sound of their own voices.

He is at once the most immediate and the most isolated of poets, this man who is always talking to someone who cannot answer. He is certainly a poet of stature, and has been recognized for a long time as one of the greatest of the Latin Americans. Now his light begins to fall the length of the hemisphere.

JOHN KNOEPFLE

A Note on César Vallejo

CÉSAR VALLEJO is the greatest modern Peruvian poet. I think Vallejo is one of the greatest modern poets in any language with which I am familiar at all; and it seems to me he is great for reasons which are quite clear, though rare for us to think of. In his poetry, he draws strength from every kind of reverence which he knows, including his reverence for his own life; and he uses his strength in order to confront and to overcome the most cruel difficulties of the twentieth century. He overcame them in the sense that he sought them out, wrote of them and in them with uncompromising clarity, and saved his own soul alive. He never flinched away from a struggle against any threat to human life — his own life or the lives of other human beings. His most profound source of imagination is his courage.

He rejoiced in his own determination to go on living in the face of every kind of death, from the vicious jealousy of university professors in Peru, when his first book *(Los Heraldos Negros,* 1918) was published, to the unsettled life of cold and hunger that he endured in Paris.

No one has yet written a full biography of Vallejo, and there are not very many external facts to guide us through his life. He was born in Santiago de Chuco, Peru, in 1893. He died in Paris in 1938. His home town was small and provincial, with an ancient and living tradition of large, affectionate families who were of necessity mobilized, as it were, against the physical and spiritual onslaughts of death in its ancient and modern forms: disease, undernourish-

ment, and cold on the one hand; the officials of the tungsten mines on the other. From his childhood and youth in Santiago de Chuco to his manhood in Europe, we see Vallejo continually reaching out into more and more profound regions of thought and action. But it would be a mistake to see his expansions as so many steps where, each time, he left a little of his life behind. On the contrary, his journeys from his home town to the city of Trujillo, and thence to Lima, and thence to Paris, and to Madrid, and back to Paris again are not renunciations of his provincial life, but spiritual as well as physical journeys during which he gains a little more illumination of his own home, his own family, his own soul. His poems cover a great range of experience, both external and internal; but he is always returning to poems about his family, poems which in their intensity and daring are more beautiful than any other poems on the subject that I have seen.

The beauty of Vallejo's poems should itself be adequate justification for publishing a translation of them. Despite the work of H. R. Hays and a few others, we in North America do not know much about this great poet. We scarcely know of his existence. A reader may ask however just what a poet in the United States may hope to learn from Vallejo. Current poets in the United States seem to be perishing on either side of a grey division between century-old British formalism on the one hand and a vandalism of anti-poetry on the other. In Vallejo we may see a great poet who lives neither in formalism nor in violence, but in imagination. He had the courage and stamina to bring his poetic imagination to bear on many different kinds of

reality — the natural reality of hunger and pain, the immorality of fascism, the inner real world of the soul — and to make whole poems out of this confrontation. This is why I think he is an important poet.

JAMES WRIGHT

From

THE BLACK RIDERS (1918)

(Los Heraldos Negros)

LOS HERALDOS NEGROS

Hay golpes en la vida, tan fuertes . . . Yo no sé!
Golpes como del odio de Dios; como si ante ellos,
la resaca de todo lo sufrido
se empozara en el alma . . . Yo no sé!

Son pocos, pero son . . . Abren zanjas oscuras
en el rostro más fiero y en el lomo más fuerte.
Serán tal vez los potros de bárbaros atilas;
o los heraldos negros que nos manda la Muerte.

Son las caídas hondas de los Cristos del alma,
de alguna fe adorable que el Destino blasfema.
Esos golpes sangrientos son las crepitaciones
de algún pan que en la puerta del horno se nos
quema.

Y el hombre . . . Pobre . . . pobre! Vuelve los
ojos, como
cuando por sobre el hombro nos llama una palmada;
vuelve los ojos locos, y todo lo vivido
se empoza, como un charco de culpa, en la mirada.

Hay golpes en la vida, tan fuertes . . . Yo no sé!

THE BLACK RIDERS

There are blows in life so violent — Don't ask me!
Blows as if from the hatred of God; as if before them,
the deep waters of everything lived through
were backed up in the soul . . . Don't ask me!

Not many; but they exist . . . They open dark ravines
in the most ferocious face and in the most bull-like
back.
Perhaps they are the horses of that heathen Attila,
or the black riders sent to us by Death.

They are the slips backward made by the Christs
of the soul,
away from some holy faith that is sneered at by
Events.
These blows that are bloody are the crackling sounds
from some bread that burns at the oven door.

And man . . . poor man! . . . poor man! He swings
his eyes, as
when a man behind us calls us by clapping his hands;
swings his crazy eyes, and everything alive
is backed up, like a pool of guilt, in that glance.

There are blows in life so violent . . . Don't ask me!

Translated by Robert Bly